

Community of Practice T&L

Meeting 7

24 June 2026

This session focused on two interconnected areas: International and Competition, and was joined by the Faculty's Associate Dean International, Susie Khamis. The discussion explored the role of international students, reputation and international impact in shaping the future of the Faculty, while also considering how we position ourselves alongside other universities, particularly within Sydney and Australia. Building on themes that emerged throughout previous sessions, the conversation examined what makes FDS distinctive in an increasingly competitive higher education landscape. As with previous meetings, the discussion considered what we are currently doing well, where opportunities for growth exist, and what assumptions or practices we may need to move beyond.

Meeting #	Topic if Inquiry
1	Intros
2	What are we good at, what do we improve on, what do we let go of
3	technology
4	Student Experience
5	Indigenous Knowledge
6	(c)reativity
7	Interdisciplinarity
8	International
10	Competition

Below is the summary of Meeting 7.

What are we Great at

Location, Industry Connections and Reputation

- UTS is viewed as a premier destination in Australia for many of the disciplines represented within the Faculty.
- For international students, three factors were consistently identified as major strengths:
 - Location
 - Industry connections
 - Reputation
- Our city campus location is a significant competitive advantage:
 - Located in the centre of Sydney
 - Access to major cultural, commercial and creative precincts
 - Embedded within the Tech Central precinct
 - Strong proximity to industry and employment opportunities
- Our reputation with industry remains a major strength. Industry recognises the quality of our graduates and values the capabilities they bring into the workplace.

Student Experience

- We provide strong support to international students throughout their studies.
- Faculty academics maintains a close relationship with students. Compared to many competitors, there is a strong culture of mutual respect and familiarity between students and teaching staff.
- Students value regular feedback and continuous touchpoints throughout the semester. This approach helps reduce anxiety associated with major assessments and examinations.

Facilities and Learning Environments

- We offer access to specialised facilities, technologies and equipment that are not commonly available elsewhere.
- Students learn in creative environments that differ significantly from conventional classroom settings.
- These facilities and learning environments contribute to the distinctiveness of the student experience.

Faculty Identity

- The Faculty presents itself authentically through the work of its students.
- Examples such as student-designed merchandise demonstrate the value of showcasing student creativity and capability rather than relying on generic marketing materials.

Staff Relationships

- Sessional academics are well supported in our faculty. There is an opportunity to further strengthen these relationships by allowing the faculty strategy to speak to sessional academics, strengthening our message to them and attracting them to continue to teach with us.

What Do We Want To Be Great At?

Faculty Identity, Culture and Storytelling

- We need a stronger and more coherent narrative about who we are as a Faculty and what makes us distinct.
- There is an opportunity to better articulate our strengths to international audiences and communicate a clearer story about the value of an FDS education.
- Clarity is needed around the qualifications, capabilities and graduate outcomes that we promote as key selling points.
- There is also a need to better communicate the diversity of disciplines within the Faculty.
- Many disciplines do not identify as creative in the traditional sense, and there is value in developing a definition of creativity that is inclusive of both making and non-making disciplines.

Sydney as a Strategic Advantage

- Western Sydney University has successfully leveraged its location and identity as part of its institutional narrative.
- There is an opportunity for UTS to more intentionally position itself around its location in Central Sydney and better communicate the opportunities this creates for students.

International Student Experience

- International students can sometimes struggle to integrate into classrooms and establish meaningful connections with domestic students.
- There is an opportunity to create a stronger international student experience that actively supports cross-cultural engagement and collaboration.
- Assessment design may play a role in this by encouraging diverse group work and meaningful collaboration between students from different backgrounds.
- It is important that all students (domestic and international) see the Faculty as an inclusive, welcoming and safe environment where they can be themselves.

Diversity and Creativity

- Diverse perspectives strengthen creativity, innovation and learning.
- There is an opportunity for the Faculty to take greater ownership of diversity as a driver of creativity and position this as a defining characteristic of the student experience.

Global Opportunities and Recognition

- Students benefit greatly from participating in internationally recognised initiatives and experiences that strengthen their portfolios and graduate outcomes.
- There is an opportunity to create a more coordinated Faculty-wide approach to these opportunities so they become a recognised feature of the student experience across all disciplines.

Student Choice and Flexibility

- Some competing universities provide students with greater agency to shape their degree and explore different pathways.
- There is value in exploring how flexibility and student choice can be further strengthened within the Faculty.

Student Support and Administration

- Student support extends beyond teaching and learning.
- Administrative processes can have a significant impact on student experience and wellbeing.
- Faster and more responsive administrative support would reduce anxiety and improve the overall student experience.

Facilities and Access

- Offering our students 24-hour access to buildings and facilities will give us an edge over our competition.
- There is an opportunity to consider how access to Faculty spaces can better support student learning, creativity and community.

Scholarships and Student Attraction

- Faculty-based scholarships and targeted support mechanisms could strengthen the Faculty's ability to attract and retain high-quality students from a broader range of international markets, further strengthening our position of creating inclusive and diverse cohorts.

What Should We Move Beyond?

International Students as Revenue

- International students should not be viewed primarily as a source of revenue.
- International students make significant contributions to the academic, cultural and social life of the Faculty.
- Recruitment strategies should recognise the broader value that international students bring to teaching, learning and the student experience.

Reliance on Limited International Markets

- COVID highlighted the risks associated with relying too heavily on a small number of international markets.
- Diversifying the international student cohort remains important for the long-term resilience of both the Faculty and the University.
- A broader and more diverse international student population enriches the student experience and strengthens the Faculty's global outlook.